This Is How New York City Takes Out Its Trash

Podcast: Odd lots

AI Executive Summary

Core Thesis

The episode delves into the complex and evolving landscape of trash collection in New York City, emphasizing the challenges and innovations in managing a city's waste. The core thesis is that while trash collection is often seen as a mundane and apolitical task, it is deeply intertwined with urban planning, political ideology, and public health. The discussion highlights the need for data-driven, innovative solutions to address the unique challenges of New York City's dense urban environment, while also acknowledging the political and logistical hurdles involved.

Key Arguments & Data

- **Historical Context and Urban Planning:**
- The 1811 street grid in New York City, which lacks alleyways, has significantly influenced the city's trash collection methods.
- The transition from metal garbage cans to black plastic bags in 1968, driven by the sanitation strikes, has had lasting impacts.

- New York City is the first in North America to implement on-street containerization, with a 70,000 block volumetric analysis to optimize placement.

- **Data-Driven Solutions:**

- The Department of Sanitation conducted a comprehensive volumetric analysis to determine the volume of trash generated in each block.

- The transition from measuring the weight of trash to measuring its volume was a significant shift, requiring advanced data collection and analysis.

- **Logistical Challenges:**

- The placement of on-street containers is a complex issue, involving considerations such as space constraints, building layouts, and street infrastructure.

- The development of a new side-loading truck for residential areas was a significant technical challenge, taking about 10 months to design and implement.

- **Political and Social Implications:**

- The decision to not implement a pay-as-you-go system for trash collection has political and social implications, with heavy wasters potentially subsidizing lighter users.

- The war on rats, a single issue voter initiative during the Adams administration, highlights the public health and quality of life concerns associated with trash collection.

- **Comparative Analysis:**

- New York City's trash collection system is compared to other cities like Barcelona, Amsterdam, and Singapore, highlighting the unique challenges and opportunities for improvement.
- The episode also touches on the broader implications for urban planning and infrastructure, with other cities like Los Angeles and Portland rethinking their public works agencies.

Actionable Takeaways

- **Investment in Data and Analysis:**
- Cities should invest in comprehensive data collection and analysis to optimize waste management systems, especially in densely populated areas.

- Data-driven approaches can help in making informed decisions about the placement and design of waste collection infrastructure.

- **Innovative Solutions:**

- Developing new technologies and systems, such as side-loading trucks, can significantly improve the efficiency and safety of waste collection.

- Exploring international best practices, like Singapore and Amsterdam, can provide valuable insights for urban planning and waste management.

- **Public Engagement and Education:**

- Public awareness campaigns and education programs are crucial for encouraging responsible waste disposal and reducing littering.

- Engaging community leaders and property owners in the planning and implementation process can help in ensuring the success of new waste management systems.

- **Political and Social Considerations:**

- Policymakers should consider the broader social and political implications of waste management systems, such as the impact on heavy wasters and the need for equitable solutions.

- Addressing public concerns and pushback is essential for the successful implementation of new waste management systems.

- **Continuous Improvement:**

- Regular reviews and updates of waste management systems are necessary to adapt to changing conditions and technologies.
- Embracing a willingness to change and innovate can help in addressing the unique challenges of urban waste management.

Diarized Transcript

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SPEAKER_01: Join me every week for the Wall Street Week podcast to hear stories of capitalism from around the world, from geopolitical tensions and central bank decisions to artificial intelligence, energy and infrastructure. We sit down with the CEOs, economists, policymakers and thought leaders whose decisions are shaping markets everywhere we find them. Subscribe to the Wall Street Week podcast on Apple, Spotify or anywhere you listen.

SPEAKER_02: Hello and welcome to another episode of the odd thoughts podcast. I'm Tracy Allaway. And I'm Joe Wiesenthal. Joe, I was talking trash with a guy at a party recently. Go on. No, I met this guy at a party. And you know, some people are so into their work, an area of expertise that they just start talking to you about it. And this guy happened to be an expert in trash. That's really cool. I don't know much about trash. I'm impressed at like.

SPEAKER_09: what a complex logistical operation it must be to collect trash in a city like New York City. Yeah, I also understand that, you know, it's sort of one of those classic things where is it their cliche? Like there's no Democrat or Republican way to pick up trash. That's like a lot. Some famous politician once said that and they were talking about city management and what makes city management different than other sort of.

SPEAKER_02: Political things like the trash isn't picked up. It's not picked up and it's not an ideological thing Well, it's interesting you say that because the person I was talking to at this party who we're about to have on the show as a guest Described trash collection in New York City is one of the

the last services untouched by neoliberalism and that's when I knew I knew we had to have him on all thoughts and then he introduced his wife as his garbage queen and then I was doubly sure that we needed to have him on all thoughts, but Trash collection is such a fascinating thing. I wasn't planning on doing an episode on it, but I've been converted, I guess, after this conversation. Because you think about in a city like New York, just how much trash has to be dealt with on a daily basis. And obviously, in New York specifically, it's not like we're putting it in the city. We have to find other places to store our trash. And at the same time, New York City is not well known for being the cleanest place in the world. In fact, we famously stick our garbage out in bags on the curb and wait for collection. And we are in a giant process of trying to change that. So there's a lot to discuss here. There's a lot to discuss. By the way, that quote, according to Google Gemini, there's no Republican or Democratic way to pick up the garbage. Former Mayor Fiorello LaGuardia was the one who said that. And so.

SPEAKER_09: He is out running as a Republican on a fusion nonpartisan. Anyway, that's not the point. But it is, you know, it's just a thing either you do it or you don't. And people get really upset. And if you don't, New York is tricky for multiple reasons. But, you know, you think in a suburb. Right. You put the trash out, but there aren't cars in the way between the trash bins and the garbage truck, et cetera, because they're in the driveway or the garage or something like that. New York has all kinds of things in between the road and the bins. I know there's, you know, there's this big effort to do containerization. I think at one point or headlines about some, you know.

SPEAKER_02: outside study from like McKinsey, et cetera. There's a lot of interesting logistical questions about trash collection. And so it's a quartet. Even though we haven't done it, it sits firmly in our wheelhouse. Absolutely. All right. So without further ado, we have the perfect guest. We're going to be speaking with Joshua Goodman. He is, of course, deputy commissioner at New York City's Department of Sanitation. So, Josh, thanks so much for coming on. Thank you both for having me. Is trash collection apolitical?

SPEAKER_03: So obviously, we all admire and respect Marila Guardia. It's a famous quote. You hear it all the time. You hear paraphrases it all the

time. It's patently untrue, right? The moment you start to dissect it, you realize that, of course, an enormous public space logistical initiative is going to be colored by ideology. Partisanship, maybe not. But the sort of implication behind the quote, that it's a binary, yes, it's picked up, no, it's not picked up, really undersells substantially the amount of planning that needs to go into this, both in the short term and in the long term. In New York City, we at the Department of Sanitation pick up, process, and export 24 million pounds of trash, recycling, and compostable material every single day. One of the things I like to tell people is that there's a word that you'll hear a lot, Sisyphean, right? And you hear it used imprecisely, in my opinion. It's often used as just a synonym for heart. Oh, school was a Sisyphean task or this home improvement project, whatever. But it ended. Right. And we have the definitional Sisyphean task. Just as Sisyphus faced the boulder again each day, we pick up 24 million pounds today. We pick up 24 million pounds tomorrow. We pick up 24 million pounds the next day. There will never be a time when DSNY says, great news, everyone. We got it all. Exactly. This is, as Tracy mentioned, we think of it as the last free, unlimited service. There's no sign up. There's no opt-in. There's no means test. You put it out, we come and get it. It's basically us in the public library at this point. And that means, and that's specific to New York, of course, but it means that as we think about changes in global best practices, we need to keep that commitment to full universal service. I don't want to like, um,

SPEAKER_09: get too bogged down in this question of Sisyphean and the philosophy of what the Greeks were trying to teach with the lesson of Sisyphus and the philosophers like Camus and so forth who studied Sisyphus over the years. But one element of that lesson is the boulder. Yes, it was endless and it never ended much like trash collection, but there was no purpose to it. There was no internal satisfaction that one could. perceived from the outside, whereas helping the public that could, in theory, be satisfactory. So had Sisyphus pushed up the boulder every day and then something great happened to the land, oh, it was clean. Maybe that would have been satisfying internally. And what's tortuous about the Sisyphean metaphor is that there does not seem to be any reward for it. Well, it is true that most New Yorkers think of cleanliness as the natural state, right? It's not.

SPEAKER_03: Wow, you did a great job. Are you sure about that? Well, that's the goal. The idea is that a street is supposed to be clean. And you mentioned Camus. Our guy at sanitation is actually SART because many people notice black bags of trash. They notice piles of trash. They rarely have ever noticed the absence of piles of trash. And so there is a philosophical element to this. But obviously, I know we're going to spend a lot more time on the details today. We could just talk about Camus and SART the whole time. What it really came down to was about four or five years ago, But we had spent decades of people coming to New York from Barcelona, from Buenos Aires, from Paris, from London, even from Chicago and LA, and saying, why do you live like this? And for many decades, our answer had basically been like, well, have you tried a bagel? We have much better pizza than you do. We had not gotten serious about addressing these challenges in a meaningful, long-term way. And that's what's begun to change over the last few years. through a process that we call the trash revolution, which is a complete reimagining of the relationship that eight and a half million New Yorkers have with 24 million pounds of trash a day, what they expect from us, what we expect from them, and it's required an enormous amount of data analysis.

SPEAKER_02: of streetscape redesign, of work across agencies, of breaking down silos. And fortunately, it's getting results. There's a lot we can talk about that really shows that this is working. Before we get into all the ins and outs of the trash revolution, which I love as a designation, how did black bags of garbage become a thing in New York in the first place? Because I remember this was one of the big culture shocks when I first moved to New York. for college and then I dropped out. So I was only here for two or three weeks. Maybe all the trash bags had something to do with it. But walking down the street, coming from places like London and Tokyo and seeing these bags of trash laid out, it was kind of weird. Yeah, there are really two key events that led to New York's unique status here. One is the 1811 street grid in New York City. The only nonrenewable resource is public space.

SPEAKER_03: There is a finite amount of room. And so when the streets were laid out in the 1811 master plan, the city was built without alleyways. You go to Chicago, which has similar density. There are alleys behind

almost all buildings to store the trash. So if you're watching a movie and it's set in New York and someone jumps out of a dark alley, it's almost certainly shot in Chicago or an LA soundstage because we don't really have them. So that meant there was no storage space behind the buildings, which other cities have. And then throughout much of the 19th and 20th century, the city used sort of the old Oscar the Grouch metal garbage can. Following the 1968 sanitation strikes, the last major New York City sanitation labor action, there was an overflowing amount more than those metal cans can handle. And when the strike was resolved, Mayor Lindsay put together a group to study a number of after effects of the Issues the city had faced during that time one of which was a task force called the committee on the black bag It studied plastic trash bags, which were basically new at that time and the plastics industry Pushed them as rodent resistant, which obviously we know they're not And you can easily find New York Times coverage from that time of people proudly stating that the transition from metal garbage cans to black bags will reduce rats while freeing up public space. Obviously it became clear almost immediately that that was not the case, but it took another five decades or so to get serious about promoting a new solution. So I understand, and we're going to get into this, that there are different approaches, et cetera, to picking up the trash, et cetera.

SPEAKER_09: But why is the LaGuardia quote wrong? Like I understand different views, but that still doesn't necessarily mean to me, it still seems like it could be right in the sense that different views don't necessarily map to politics. But it's true that it's not a neat left right split necessarily, but it's not true that there that who you put into office has no bearing on what happens to the trash, right? I think this point was that it transcends ideology and it doesn't or else this would have been done a long time ago. OK, then what are the different

SPEAKER_03: ideological frameworks from which we can view the question of optimal trash collection. So one of the things to think about is that cleanliness is not just an abstract concept. It has a tremendous impact on a person's quality of life. Every morning, hundreds of thousands of New Yorkers get up, they go out, they go to work, they go to school. If they walk down a dirty street, the first thing they think is no one cares about me. I can't necessarily blame people for feeling that way. Often thoughts about

kindliness in public space are, you have to think about who you're prioritizing, right? So is it someone who spends the bulk of their time in public in a car versus someone who spends the bulk of their time in public walking? Is it someone for whom a rat is a curiosity versus a reality that they have to live with? I kind of like the rats. I get really bored walking down the street and seeing some wildlife, which in New York City is just pigeons and rats. I get it. Look, I love all animals. I'm a longtime vegan. But the fact is that there is a Jungian reaction to a rat for most people. You walk down a street in New York, and a rat runs across your foot. You remember it every time you're on that block for the rest of your life. And the same goes for public space trash, which I know certain New Yorkers have sort of romanticized. I think that you can only do that if it's not your reality, that living around trash and rats is not a good thing. And we would like it to. People sometimes assume that anyone at the Department of Sanitation loves the trash. And I always tell them, no, no, no, our job is to get rid of it. We hate the trash. The trash is our enemy, as fascinating as it is to study. And so when we thought about putting global best practices into place just the last few years, this is actually a very data-driven agency, probably not surprising. But we had about a century of data about the weight of the trash, which had long been our primary metric for efficiency. And what we needed was data about the volume of the trash. That's what you need for containerization programs. And so we had to do a 70,000 block volumetric analysis. We went block by block and converted those weights into volumes and developed the programs that are coming out now. And there were a lot of different, both left and right, thoughts about what approach we should take, if any. We've developed a strategy that we think will work for the unique streetscape of New York. When I first got involved in this work, I would often hear from people, well, there's no place as dense as New York that does this. Not true. There's no place with as much weather flexibility as New York. Not true. There's no place that produces as much volume of trash. Not true. We actually produce per person less trash than most other Western cities. There's no reason that they can have this everywhere else in the world other than

SPEAKER_02: a political inertia, right? And that's what's begun to change based on the data that we've produced. Well, to me, one of the obvious political choices that's been made in New York is also we don't have a pay

as you go service, or you're not paying per pound of trash that you produce, right? I can produce a lot of trash, and it's sort of incumbent on the city to collect it versus someone who's trying their best to recycle and compost and things like that. Why don't we talk about logistics for a second just to better understand the current state so that we can figure out where we're trying to get to. I take out a bag of trash from my apartment building and it's a Wednesday in SoHo and I place it on the curb. What happens to it from there? So a collection truck, we don't call them garbage trucks because they also pick up recycling and compost, comes by sometime generally between midnight and

SPEAKER_03: 830 in the morning, try to get as much of it done before peak rush hour. The trucks are on routes that are optimized for a few things. They hold about 12 to 13 tons of trash each. You want it to get full on its route and you want the route to be completed in a single shift. So they're optimized around those factors. And then once the truck is full or loaded out as the jargon, it's taken to a network of transfer stations. So prior to 2000, it was all taken to the Staten Island landfill. When the landfill closed, the city moved to a waste export model. It was a multi-billion dollar 15 year infrastructure project to build five transfer stations around the city. These are places where the truck comes. It dumps out onto a big floor, the tipping floor, a big floor where a large front end loader pushes it down holes in the floor into like a shipping container that's underneath. Robotic arms seal up the shipping container a giant crane puts it on either a barge or a rail car And it's taken to its final destination outside the city. This is obviously far more environmentally sustainable than an in-city landfill and Also, then the old trucking model right barges and rail cars much much better for the environment when you see these barges with 50 or 75 Packed storage containers on them. You think wow that would have been 75 trucks driving to a landfill That's for your regular trash. Refuse is the term that appears in our materials. For your metal, glass, and plastic, they're taken to a facility in Sunset Park where they're pelletized and prepared to be sold on the recycling market. New York City is a great opportunity for me to mention something really important, which is lots of people in sort of the demographic that listens to odd lots, educated, smart people, the cocktail party set. think that it makes them sound really smart to say, I heard recycling is a scam. Didn't someone once tell me? I have to tell you, I can't

speak for other municipalities. New York City's recycling system is protected by long term contracts that guarantee beneficial reuse of those materials. If you properly sort a can or bottle in New York City, it will become a new can or bottle or other usable item. Wait, slight tangent. What about a styrofoam cup? So styrofoams are banned in the city, right? So you shouldn't see them too often. Styrofoam actually hits on the great issue with this. Styrofoam is often used as the archetypical example of a non recyclable item on a pure molecular level, of course, it can be recycled. It's just plastic. The issue is that it's so light that no plastics manufacturer would ever feel that they had enough in one space to make money off of it. It's a good example of how this is actually a market based system for recycling specifically, because many more things are recyclable from a chemical standpoint than are actually accepted as recycling in New York City. You probably know that in 2017, 2018, there were domestic policy changes in China that collapsed a lot of cities recycling markets. New York was protected from those changes by a long term strategic planning. Before that, we also had resisted an urge that a lot of cities gave into in a few years before that to combine their paper and their metal, glass and plastic. Oh, it's easier for residents. It turned out to be a huge money loser for cities that did it and also for the environment. when this market change happened in 1718. What was the argument for doing that? Because when I think about it in my head, it's like, well, of course, it's going to cost more to sort it out. The idea was more people will participate because it's easier, which is a good motivating principle in general. But on this specific topic, the technology is not there yet, or at least we don't feel the technology is there yet. Your paper, just to get back to where it all goes, it goes to Staten Island, where It is actually one of the fastest processes in the waste stream. Cardboard and paper that you recycle today might become a new pizza box tomorrow. Pizza boxes are one of the primary things made at that facility. And then your compost, which is sort of our best and newest and most exciting stream. Your food waste goes to a few places, but primarily to our Staten Island compost facility It's a 33 acre site where over a period of three or four months we turn and aerate Your material until it's broken down into finished compost which we give away to parks and gardens to residents directly We just finished our summer compost give back season. We gave away about 15 million pounds of finished compost to New Yorkers NYC.gov slash get compost you can find events near you to get 40 pound

bags And some of it goes to the Department of Environmental Protection's New Town Creek Digester Eggs. If you've been on the BQE, right as you go over the Cushusco and come between Brooklyn and Queens, you'll see the big eggs. Those are large facilities where your food waste will be mixed with wastewater. So it gets mixed there with everything that you put down the sink or that you flush down the toilet where it's digested into biosolids for fertilizer and usable biogas that heats homes in Brooklyn.

SPEAKER_06: So, your waste goes to a lot of different places, but the idea is to divert as much of it as possible to beneficial use and hopefully to reduce the total amount over time. What's next for virtual assets? I'm Jacob Greaves, host of Economy Scale, a series exploring growth in key global sectors. And in this episode, we're diving into the digital forces shaping finance. Sean McHugh from the Dubai-based virtual assets regulatory authority has this to say. We're seeing a lot of institutional players come in, digital asset dedicated hedge funds, high-frequency traders and that sort of thing, and folks who service institutional clients. As more capital enters the market, adaptive regulation is likely to become increasingly key.

SPEAKER_07: Rhys Merrick of Ripple says, a lot of regulators globally would like to keep the industry at arm's length. That's the opposite here. I think also what you'll find is that regulation and frameworks can come out, but some of them are maybe a slight iteration on some 80 year old policy and not actually in line with what the technology can do and offer. And again, that's very different in Dubai. Listen to the full episode wherever you get your podcasts. This series is brought to you by Bloomberg Media Studios and the Dubai Department of Economy and Tourism.

SPEAKER_12: The future of wealth is being rewritten. On November 12th, Bloomberg Invest Dubai brings together leading investors, family offices and business leaders to explore where capital goes next. Hear from the UAE's Minister of Investment, the President of PIMCO, the founder of EMAR, as well as other global leaders in investment and finance, and leaders from Blackstone, PIMCO and more. Geopolitics, private capital, the opportunities shaping 2027 and beyond. Bloomberg Invest Dubai, November 12th. Host partner, Dubai Department of Economy and Tourism. Supporting sponsors, Deutsche Bank Wealth Management and Omnia.

SPEAKER_09: I'm thinking about that guy. And it's a guy at the cocktail party. So it's like, you know, it's like the classic like I heard two minute segment on the radio once. I hate that guy. I think a lot of listeners are better than that. They only say things if they've researched the topic for at least 30 minutes. They certainly I'm sure a lot of listeners know that person, at least they know. Oh, my God. I can't stand that person. On the other hand, and I don't want to get into it. The fact that like New York has guaranteed contracts anyway does not necessarily vindicate recycling. I might vindicate it from the New York City perspective, but let's move on. All right. That's the old that's a rough overview of, let's say, the the old regime. Why don't you give us the equivalent sort of like rough overview of the new regime of like what what we're going. So the big changes in what I just described were that were conducted between 2000 and 2015 to move from.

SPEAKER_03: Landfill model to waste export model. Those were huge back-of-house changes on our operation And what we're doing now is making sort of front-of-house changes for how New Yorkers interact with the trash It's actually I don't mean to use it as an excuse But it's one of the reasons why as other cities move to on-street containerization New York didn't we have this big project going on a transfer stations? Obviously we should be able to do both. But so now what we're doing is

SPEAKER_02: after we completed this 70,000 block volumetric analysis. Can you say a little bit more about the analysis? Because I don't even know how you would start such a project. Because if you look at an apartment building, it's like, OK, maybe they produce like X pounds of waste on a certain day. But then the day after Christmas, that suddenly explodes and becomes five times as much. Yeah, absolutely. So when you look at

SPEAKER_03: One thing that I think is important to remember as we talk about this is that even though New York has a reputation for being behind the curve, there's actually no city in North America that does on-street containerization. It's a purely European, South American, and Asian thing. And when this program is implemented, New York will have gone, I would never say worse, but have gone from the back of the pack to first. And that means that we had to develop a system that would work for us specifically. As we first started to confront this, I heard a lot from sort of two groups,

urbanists who would say, this is a solved problem, copy paste Barcelona, copy paste Amsterdam, and also community leaders in the city who said this would never work here, right? And when we did this study, what we really found was that both of those groups were wrong. It is of course achievable and it is of course difficult. So when we had all this data about the weight of the trash, what we wanted to do was... Again, as I mentioned that you there's a finite amount of street space you want to establish a containerization model that can hold all the waste but that is not Oversized because then you're wasting that space so we planned for one extra day You mentioned Christmas and we planned for basically one extra day above their collection and we went out and measured piles of trash We eventually were able to come up with conversion formula to use but it was a lot of on-the-street work measuring both the trash itself and also the streetscape, because you might know the length of a block, but you know that you can't put the bin in front of a curb cut. You know it can't go in front of a fire hydrant. We had determined that we were going to go with a side loading model. There are different ways the trucks can be serviced. That meant that we had to think about tree canopy height. The bin can't go up into the tree. There are so many factors in really four dimensions on this to consider. And in Europe in particular, What you see are open shared bins. And this is what had kind of been contemplated in earlier pilots that we had done going back to 2021. OK, just a European style, basically a dumpster on the street that everybody on the block has to use. We always had a lot of issues with that as an at scale solution because a few reasons. First of all, in New York City, we provide this free unlimited service for residents. Businesses have to pay for trash collection. and through a network of private carters. And so there was a concern about, well, if it's a free open bin, why wouldn't a business just steal space in that bin with their trash in there? So we didn't want to go forward with that model. We also knew that there are many neighborhoods in the city where an on-street container was not going to improve the situation. If you think about a low density neighborhood, making everybody all of a sudden walk down to the middle of the block, that doesn't help, just in the name of saying, well, we've done the whole city. So the model we eventually came up with after we had this volumetric data was a containerization system for low density buildings one to nine residential units a single-family home up through a small apartment using a wheeled trash bin and then eventually a specific wheeled trash bin the largest

buildings 31 or more units is the point we came up with where they can certainly support at least one of what we call Empire bins the on-street containers And then the 10 to 30s, the mid-sized buildings, was where we found there's a lot of variety. Might be 11 studios, there's 11 people in the building, versus 29 two bedrooms. They have to use one or the other, but they choose. And that program with that model was implemented in the cities divided into 59 community districts. We began in one community district, Manhattan 9, which is West Harlem, Amsterdam to the river, 111 to 155. in June of last year, 2025. And now, fall 2026, this is coming to a second district, Brooklyn Community District 2, which is downtown Brooklyn, through Fort Greene, Clinton Hill, Brooklyn Heights. That is the point that this really moves beyond a pilot and becomes a real program that New Yorkers can expect to see in their neighborhood. And the mayor has actually committed to funding this program for a full rollout by the end of 2031.

SPEAKER_09: I'm kind of curious, like, I actually don't know which what I have right now. So what I have right now in my damning indictment of how often you take out the trash every day. But like, so the way like you take it to a central location, right? No, I we have like this sort of like I live in a building that's like four units is like fairly small in the East Village. And I don't just like put my trash out on the street. We have like this closed container and then I lift it up and then, et cetera. Walk me through. from the perspective of the sanitation worker. So what are they doing now? And to get that trash out of it? And then how will their day be different under the content? Like walk me through that when they're going down my block? What does it look like today? And what does it look like when this is implemented? These photos are great example, because you'll have every kind of building within a single there. So a sanitation worker is not servicing the container that you're describing.

SPEAKER_03: It's like up against the building wall. Yeah, it's up against the building. Someone that your landlord is paying is coming and moving the material out to the curb. That's actually one of the things that we were able to build it. Well, someone is coming and moving it out. Our building hires this person. In New York City, most buildings are required to have a professional waste manager, someone who takes the trash out. And we

wanted to maintain that system because they do a lot of things and because it builds cleanliness in the neighborhood in general, right? So right now, Those bags are coming out of your sealed container. They're going to the curb. Sanitation workers are taking them out and putting them in the back. They should be going out, because you have fewer than nine units, in an official NYC bin. And if they are not, you are subject to a summons as of September of this year. Slow down. Let's slow down. But the trash is essentially not supposed, from a building of your size, not supposed to sit on the ground directly anymore. It never does, actually. So it goes out in a bin. Sanitation workers can either tip the bin manually, or soon the trucks will have a rear tipper for the small buildings. Yeah, we have the real bins. So they have the bar on them, the bar hooks up to the rear tipper, and it goes in the back. For the Empire bin, for larger buildings, we had to design an all-new truck for this. I mentioned that New York City is the first place in North America to do on-street containerization. Once we studied rear loading versus side loading, container model, we came up with what we wanted to do. And we discovered that one of the long pulls in the tent was going to be that there was no what's called an automated side loader ASL truck that was appropriate for residential use in New York City. Like they have one that they use at the Port of Philadelphia. I saw this thing operate. It was so like the idea that it was going to come down your street was was ludicrous. So we talked to some truck industry experts and heard that it would probably take about five years to design a truck from scratch. You can't just import the ones from Europe. There's different emission standards. We were not going to wait five years for that. So we actually got involved in the Department of Sanitation in the truck design business, something I knew nothing about going into this. And we learned how to do it. And we got a prototype truck built in about 10 months. And that's the truck that is now rolling off the line. It's operating in West Harlem. We're getting them in for the other districts going forward. So it's a combination of vendors. This is actually how we were able to do it so quickly. It's the European body, the side loading body. And Mac makes the chassis exactly the same as they do for many of our current collection trucks. And then we work with a firm that specializes in getting the two sets of electronics to talk to each other. And we've got about probably about 20 of them operating now out of our full fleet of 2,300 or so. But they'll continue to come in as this program rolls out over the next five or six years.

SPEAKER_02: I want to go back to something you touched on earlier, which is deciding where the bins actually go, because this is a meaningful way in which the Department of Sanitation might actually change the look and feel of New York. So when you're choosing where to put a bin, I mean, as you said, space is at a premium in New York. And there's a bunch of other stuff that could go in that bin space. You know, you could have. a parking space being the obvious one or I don't know, a space for deliveries or people to get in and out of taxi cabs, whatever. Talk a little bit more about like the decision making process for doing that and how you're judging the value of collecting trash versus other things. Absolutely. So one of the reasons that we were not interested in the European model of shared containers for the most part is because you then face this challenge of like, well, why is it in front of my house and not your house if it's for both of us?

SPEAKER_03: Under the model we came up with, where larger buildings support their own bin, it's in front of your building because it's for your building. So that eliminates a lot of the concerns about spatial jockeying. OK, I live in a 50 unit building. We get an empire bin and it goes right in front of the building. And it's important to remember that while this is taking up curb space, it's freeing up sidewalk space where the bags are currently kept for collection. So you get that space back for pedestrians. We've also heard, especially in West Harlem, from quite a few supers and waste managers who say, I love that I don't have to keep it in the building anymore. I just got 30 to 50 square feet of building space back without any new additional construction because where I used to put the trash can now go straight into the bin outside. That said, the street layout issues are huge. And we work very closely with the City Department of Transportation on coordinating around Some of the things that I mentioned, hydrants, curb cuts, we don't take designated handicap spaces. We've also in BK2, the second district that's coming online, we were interested in piloting shared containers within our locked model by buildings that opt in to share. So we said two small buildings decide they don't qualify on their own, but they want to share one. And that actually really exposed some of the street limitations. There were a handful of buildings that were interested and they were on streets with full no parking, no air, no place to put them. So it's something we'll continue to explore in future zones. But absolutely, you know, we think that the initial what we called the future of trash report back

in spring of 22, where we sort of first began to look at the feasibility of this in a meaningful way, said that on-street containerization could take up to 150,000 parking spaces. Now, that was before we had gotten into that's out of three million total in the city. That was before we had gotten into some of the details. Once we had analyzed it much further, and gone down the road on implementation. We're now looking at about a fifth of that when we went back and did the Back to the Future of Trash Report. We found that it was more like 30,000 spaces at full rollout. And it could be fewer based on the opt-ins. Can we just talk a little bit more about the perspective of the sanitation workers? Absolutely. So first of all, how many are on the truck right now?

SPEAKER_09: Two. There's two people currently. Yes. And it will still be two under the new. That's correct. And how does their like walk me through literally what they physically do? They go and collect it, et cetera. How does it look different now or future versus now? Yes. So sanitation workers have an incredibly difficult job. They're out there collecting 12 to 13 tons of trash in.

SPEAKER_03: all weather, in all conditions, they can't say, I couldn't get to it today. There's an expectation that it will be gone. And about 50% of their line of duty injuries are sprains and strains from throwing bags. So we're excited to see that go away. There are about 6,500 people with the title of sanitation worker out of 10,000 people total at the department. So those are the people who are actually collecting and processing your trash. They are subject to a number of hazards on the job. One thing we've seen a big increase is being poked by needles. We assume it's from an increase in GLP-1 usage with people buying them online. And it comes with an instruction booklet, but they don't necessarily read it because it came from an online pharmacy and whatever. And then they think, this is trash. I put it in the bag, and it goes away. And so a big thing that we want people to remember, of course, is a human being handles your garbage. But the move to mechanized collection, the side loading truck, in high density areas will make a huge difference for the backs and knees of sanitation workers. They go out. They begin their day with a roll call at their garage. I mentioned the city's divided into 59 districts. They start at one of their assigned district. They do a roll call. They get their assignment for the day. There's a big

electronic board where they find out where they're working that day. They go out with their partner and they collect the trash. And then in many but not all districts, they get to dump it at the transfer station on the same shift. Some districts where the routes are optimized differently, it's another shift comes in and empties the truck so that it's empty when people come back in the morning. These are people who deal with every possible situation you can imagine. And if we can get it so that they are not lifting your garbage as much, it will make a huge difference. What happens to bulky waste under the new system? Because one of the nice things about New York City right now is, you know, you can put a couch on a curb and Sometimes people will just take it and use it on their own. But if they don't, then the trash collectors will come and they'll throw it away. And you don't have to pay extra to do that. Yeah, no change. If there's an item that doesn't fit in your bin, a couch is a great example. Just leave it next to it. A truck will still be coming down. We hope to find efficiencies at full rollout and have to run fewer of the trucks, the rear loader, the sort of traditional. collection truck that can get bulky items. But that was actually one of the things we learned from Barcelona. Barcelona is often held up as the gold standard of waste management in urban environment. We talked to them at the beginning of this process and asked them quite a few questions about what worked and also what they would have done differently. And it was interesting because American urbanists will tell you that Barcelona is perfect. We should just do Barcelona. And the Barcelona people were like... We still have a lot of issues, one of which was that they had converted their fleet too heavily to side loaders and then learned, well, actually people still put a loose bag next to it once in a while. They still need the couch and they had to go back and get a different truck. So we're making sure to keep that as part of the program. Just out of curiosity in this international exploration, did you ever look into Mexico City because

SPEAKER_09: I've never been to a city that's A, more clean and B, you can't find a trash can for the life of you. And I'm like, where do people like put their like, you buy something from a street food vendor, you have this wrapper. And I'm like, I don't know where to throw it away. There's no trash cans anywhere. And yet the streets are spotless. I don't get it. You know, public space litter baskets and public space maintenance are different across

the world. And we have talked to them and, you know, we have responsibility here for the property owner to maintain the sidewalk.

SPEAKER_03: In Mexico City and in Tokyo, which is the other sort of famously clean streetscape city There are community groups who are paid or tasked with maintenance and we have that as well through the business improvement districts system We did in 2018 conduct a one district pilot where we tried going with the Tokyo Mexico City model and removed every litter basket Yeah, because people sometimes say like oh the litter baskets they attract the trash, you know when people yeah People littered everywhere. So that said, I don't want to preclude for your future study. It is true that piles of trash attract additional trash. And when you're in a neighborhood that is not containerized and you see a pile of black bags, it is natural to think I can put my garbage on top of it. Yeah. So my hope is that after full containerization, we can reevaluate some of that further and say, OK, now that the city broadly doesn't have trash everywhere, what can we do to limit littering and public space cleanliness issues? The Big Take podcast from Bloomberg News keeps you on top of the biggest stories of the day. My fellow Americans, this is Liberation Day.

SPEAKER_11: Stories that move markets. Chair Powell opened the door to this first interest rate cut. Impact politics. Change businesses. This is a really stunning development for the AI world and how you think about your bottom line. Listen to the big take from Bloomberg News every weekday afternoon on the iHeart radio app, Apple podcasts, or wherever you get your podcasts. This is a slightly random question, but what happened to the anti-littering?

SPEAKER_03: campaigns of like the 80s and 90s, I guess as far back as the 70s, because I feel like you just don't see them as much anymore. And it's not like I don't think you can look at New York and say mission accomplished. There's no more literary. I will say that I do think that there's some confirmation bias and selective memory about these because we ran a multimillion dollar one last year. The We Heart NYC anti littering campaign. We ran one that was well into the six figures recently that had It had a picture of a finger pointing up into an NYC litter basket and said, if you see someone littering, tell them where to stick it. We ran a few of these.

And the issue is, I think, probably the same one that you find across the media landscape of the monoculture is long over. And we try to do a tremendous amount of littering outreach. But this came up a lot in January, February this year when there was a sort of persistent dog waste issue. Oh, yeah. And I would often remind people that as frustrating as it is, and as much as we do want to and are planning to do more, there is no one in the city who doesn't clean up after their dog because they don't know the rules, right? Of course, you know, outreach and education is great, but it's not like, oh, yeah, you know, I didn't know you had to clean up after your dog, and now I saw the ad. So, you know, we do them. Every sanitation truck comes with a poster space on the side. We put anti-literary messages on those posters frequently. You know, we... love to do sort of, we've had long standing relationships with the arts community. You've probably seen the early 90s David Lynch anti-littering ad that he did with the SNY. It's something that we're interested in, but also I do think that we're at the point where we see the built environment as the bigger issue here. And I'll bring it back to some of the philosophy behind this. One of the thinkers who informed a lot of the work of the Treasure Revolution that really gets at what you're talking about is a 70s urban planner named Oscar Newman who wrote a book called Defensible Space that was basically what he did in the book was he said that controlling even for income, for age, for all demographics, he found that public housing still had a high, at that time, a higher rate of crime than market rate housing. And so what was the cause? he proposed that there were elements of the design of the space that caused this issue, specifically that there were significant parts of many urban public housing developments that didn't feel like they belonged to anyone. They were everyone's. And so he proposed a design model that would be good. So the most famous example of his design is the Yonkers row houses that were the subject of Lisa Belkin's book, Show Me a Hero, that won her the Pulitzer I guess in the late 90s. A big part of what we were thinking with this was how do we apply that same finding about crime to cleanliness? What do we do that makes it so that every part of the city belongs to someone? So that cleanliness is not just about trash removal, but about real care for public spaces. That's one of the reasons why the Empire bins are assigned to a specific building rather than shared. It's one of the reasons that we have done a lot of sort of continued expansion of the property owners are required to clean 18 inches of the street. You know, that we've done a lot

of work on that, that we have been so focused on expanding the ways in which we enforce alternate side parking, street sweeping regulations. because there should be no part of the city where someone can litter or someone can observe someone else litter and think that is not my fault. And the design that Newman put into place has been broadly seen as effective. And we're hopeful that over the next five or so years, we'll see those same design elements work on the cleanliness space.

SPEAKER_02: Tracy is it well known that um don't mess with Texas that phrase you hear a lot was an anti littering thing I know about it because my dad's Texan. Yeah, I lived in Dallas Don't mess with Texas and people think it's some sort of political thing, but it literally is just and it still is I mean some of the anti littering campaigns Exactly, but to your point. I mean this is also Yeah, this is also the problem with public shaming by the way if you see someone littering They probably know what they're doing is bad. And so pointing out to someone who's doing a bad thing, that what they're doing is bad is a little bit risky in New York sometimes. It could be. Yeah, I'm still I'm pro. I think I'm pro shaming. I'm pro public shaming, but that's different from saying that I'm comfortable doing it constantly. We don't think of anything we do as shaming. We just want people to know if you are someone who cares about your neighborhood, you are not alone. You are actually in the majority, not the person littering. Can you talk a little bit about you mentioned, OK,

SPEAKER_09: this containerization. It's in West Harlem. It's about to be in Brooklyn. So that's two of 59. Yes. And we'll start going. What is the roadmap? And like you said, like the mayor is committed to funding it through. Does that mean it's not guaranteed?

SPEAKER_03: Currently that it will be rolled out to the entire no, it's guaranteed. It's I mean we do annual budget cycles here So he's not literally there, but the commitment is as good as it gets to roll this out And we've got strong support from the City Council on this too. You know, it's funny when we first started this we heard a lot of Concerns about pushback and those concerns were mostly conceptual I bet people will be mad about parking. We heard that a lot. Very few people are actually mad about parking, but we heard a lot. I bet people are going to push back. So as far as the rollout, it

took 50 years to do the first district, another year to do the second. But we're going to do the remaining 57 in about five years as trucks start rolling off the line. Can you talk a little bit more about, you know, as you can see that to one fact, which is that you can't just copy and paste any other city's model into New York City.

SPEAKER_09: So it's not, you know, even if containerization, etc. works, it's a little different. We don't have we might not have alleys. That's a difference. We might whatever. Every city is a little bit different. But then, as you mentioned, people can take a little bit too far and convince themselves that New York is just different. Yes, it looks like you can have and then people really get dug in and they come up with stories. What is that? Where does this impulse come from that all around? You look at trash and you have like, there was an article in the New Yorker about like a trash anthropologist in the wisdom quote. It's like, oh, you don't understand New York is it really a city? It's a series of sub societies and blah, blah, blah. And it's just not like other cities. And that's why it doesn't work. Where does this impulse come from? This sort of I would call it like an anti New York exceptionalism. We just can't.

SPEAKER_03: there's something fundamental. We just can't have clean... I don't even think it's anti-New York exceptionalism. I think it's just a different manifestation of the same New York exceptionalism. Our trash is special in some ways. You know, our bags are a beautiful part of our landscape. And of course they're not. And the waste stream has changed many times before. You know, one of the impetus... Impetuses? Impetai? Impetai. For the creation of the Department of Sanitation in the first place was that in the mid to late 19th century, there were dead horses all over the city. and nobody whose job it was to pick them up. And then throughout the early 20th century, many buildings had in-building incinerators. The primary waste stream that we picked up was piles of ash. And then that moved to solid waste. We had the landfill model. This stuff has changed many times before. And I think it's the same nostalgic impulse that you see like why every movie is a sequel, because people want what they grew up with. And I think one of the big things we're trying to do is remind people that what you should be proud of is what's under the trash, right? It's not, and you know, we've done this a lot of different ways over the years. I'm

sorry, did you say what's under the trash? Sure, the streets, the people, you know. We have an artist that we've worked with for many decades, Merle Laterman-Euclides did in the early 80s, designed a collection truck that's fully mirrored on the side. And the idea is called The Social Mirror. It's a great piece. And it was intended to remind people, I make the trash. When I see the trash, that's me. And unfortunately, we bring it out to parades now and people go, oh, it's the selfie truck. It's not the selfie truck. It's the truck with a deeper meaning behind it. But to your point about reproducibility and differences, the trash in New York takes on sort of unique logistical space. We don't have the alleyways. We produce certain volumes, our density. But many cities face different challenges in the trash space and in other infrastructural areas. And I know a lot of them are looking at that now. Voters in Los Angeles have a ballot measure this year that would substantially rethink their structure of their public works agencies. I know Portland, Oregon just reorganized its city fleet asset management. DC eliminated the deputy mayor for operations two years ago and is now rethinking that decision. These are the questions, right? It's not so much necessarily about what do you do with the trash? But what do you do to say the way I've lived for 50 years is not the only way to live, right? That, you know, just as activists in this country look and say, you know, well, you know, they have this here. I want that, you know. Oh, you know, we can have what every place has. Everyone can have a standard of living that they deserve. Even as you make the trash. And even as you expect someone else to just make it go away, there is more that you can do as a resident to sort of encourage responsible design around this stuff. Setting the New York exceptionalism argument aside for one second and setting all of New York aside, do you have a favorite trash collection system internationally? Like, what's your platonic ideal of a trash collection system? So there are a couple of places that had the opportunity to build them sort of from scratch. I wouldn't call them the platonic ideal because I'm very aware that these are not replicable models, but Singapore, which did a tremendous amount of Greenfield development and was able to sort of put best practices in place from the beginning, and also Amsterdam, which was in a similar situation in the post-war era of being able to kind of restart a lot of their public space design. They used underground trash containers. had some advantages that I wish we would have had. You know, one of the things we learned in this process really surprised me was that there's actually no map of what's

underneath the streets in New York. There's no one, you know, Con Ed knows where their stuff is and the subway knows where their stuff is, but there is not one master what we started calling the underground spaghetti. All the guys who've been caught on camera coming out of the subway or out of the sewer system, they're just... They're trying to map it, right? Yeah, exactly. They're trying to figure out what's there. And my hope is that that will change. And I love the fact that in Tokyo, they have seven way streams, whereas we've just gone from three to four. They separate so many more types of material. There are things that we could take from all over the world. But I think that the biggest thing that I hope that we continue to take is just a willingness to change. By the way, if anyone's listening to this episode, you should watch it on YouTube.

SPEAKER_09: because our guest here has a really cool jacket that I'm very jealous of. And I'm always jealous of Zoran's jackets, too. He's got one of these. Yeah, I'm sure he does. And every time I see one of these press conferences, it's, oh, that's a sick jacket. You know, it's autumn in New York. No matter how cool you think your jacket is, somebody has a cooler jacket. So it's just part of the job. Josh Goodman, thank you so much for coming on All Thoughts. Really appreciate it. It was my pleasure. Thank you both so much. And don't litter.

SPEAKER_02: So that was a really interesting conversation. Something that I don't think about that much, even though I'm in New York City all the time, how our trash actually gets collected. I do think there is an underlying political architecture that is like there's a major political choice in having residential garbage not be pay as you go. True. Right. And so the big question is, if do heavy wasters basically get subsidized by people who aren't throwing out that much?

SPEAKER_09: No, you're right. There's a lot. And, you know, we could have gotten into that question of like, should it be completely, I guess, socialized? One thing I appreciate, you know, people always wanted to let go. New York City paid a million and a half dollars to McKinsey to do a study on trash. And they produced a like it's complicated. And there's two things. One is collecting the data, et cetera. These are complicated things. Yeah. And two. It would be kind of weird for a city to already have had that

expertise in house because you're not doing major studies of the track system every year. You hopefully maybe do this once every couple of decades or something like that. Yeah. So I don't know. I'm very like, I think people have this knee jerk response. Like, why did why did you pay another company to tell you that this is how they do it in Barcelona? Well, it's like, well, there's a lot of very interesting data. You know, this whole question of You asked the question, how do you switch from measuring weight of trash to volume of trash? How do you do it? Does it seem like a trivial question? I have no idea. Bring in a bunch of measurements, et cetera. So I have an appreciation for like just the amount of sort of planning work that would have to go into this. Yeah, the other the volumetric analysis seems really difficult to me. And despite that, they.

SPEAKER_02: seem to have done it and they're getting a handle on what's needed. But the other thing that's really difficult or strikes me as very difficult is the placement of the bins, right? And this idea that you are actually changing New York's landscape, hopefully for the better. But in the meantime, you are taking up previously public space.

SPEAKER_09: and having to figure out like the cost benefit analysis of doing that for literally every single building in New York. In the entire city. Yeah, that's pretty wild to think about just like how many blocks there are. But you know what, like, I mean, I understand people park on the street and stuff like that, but that's socialized, too. Why do you know that's really valuable real estate that some lucky people get to like park for free, et cetera. So.

SPEAKER_02: The only thing I'm going to miss is seeing the occasional rat eating pizza or something. We didn't get into, you know, I'm really interested in the war on rats. You know, that was, I thought, something very, very inspiring during the Adams administration is seeing those numbers of rat sightings. I remember you were a single issue voter in the war on rats. Yeah, I was. Yeah. All right. Shall we leave it there? Let's leave it there. This has been another episode of the All Thoughts Podcast. I'm Tracy Allaway. You can follow me at Tracy Allaway.

SPEAKER_09: And I'm Joe Weisenthal, you can follow me at the stalwart. Follow our guest Josh Goodman, he's at JSHGDMN. Follow our producers,

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